

The HR Numbers That Matter

A one-page cheat sheet for putting HR in the boardroom conversation

HR leaders who speak in headcount and attrition are invited to the table last. HR leaders who speak in revenue and risk have a seat before the meeting starts. Keep these seven numbers close — and always show the trend, not just the value.

- **Revenue per employee** — your headline productivity ratio. Ask: can we grow without growing headcount at the same rate?
- **Cost of a regretted departure** — replacement, ramp, and lost output; often 6–18 months of salary. Makes retention a financial case.
- **Cost of a bad hire** — the multiple of salary lost when a key role is filled badly. Frames hiring as investment risk.
- **Compensation as % of revenue** — the number CFOs use to judge whether people cost is under control.
- **Time-to-productivity** — how long a new hire takes to reach full contribution. Onboarding's real KPI.
- **Span of control** — average reports per manager. Too low signals bloat; too high signals burnout.
- **Human-capital ROI** — $(\text{revenue} - \text{non-people costs}) \div \text{people cost}$. The closest thing HR has to a return figure.

How to present them

Lead with the business question, not the metric. Attach every number to a decision the CEO or CFO is already trying to make, show the twelve-month trend, and end with a recommendation phrased in money or risk. Do it twice and watch how the meeting invitations change.